universal prescription. For perfection or freedom from error comes only from grace.' That sense of grace, of a personal and potentially wrathful God, was clearly borrowed from Gandhi's reading of Christian writings. The presence of such borrowings underlines how misleading it can be to think of Gandhi as a purely Hindu spiritual thinker: his religious views were far more complex and elusive. Significantly, he described the object of his faith loosely, and by negation: 'I have made the world's faith in God my own, and as my faith is ineffaceable, I regard that faith as amounting to experience … I have no word for characterizing my belief in God.'

One could read such a statement as an instance of a characteristic Gandhian strategy. He affected plainness and clarity, while also cultivating a deliberate ambiguity in his terminology, so allowing others to read into his words their own hopes and fears – a crucial ploy for one who had to address and appeal to so many diverse audiences: India's peasants and educated elites, British politicians and people, and world public opinion. But to see his allusive gesture at his sense of divinity merely as an example of cunningly elastic rhetoric is to miss how Gandhi, both in his own life and in the kind of universal ethics he wished to create, held fast to an idea of psychological and ethical metamorphosis.

Human personality was, for him, not pre-given and static. It was not decisively shaped either by nature or culture: instinctual fear or social prejudice, each was conquerable. Because human personality was susceptible to influence, and infinitely revisable,